

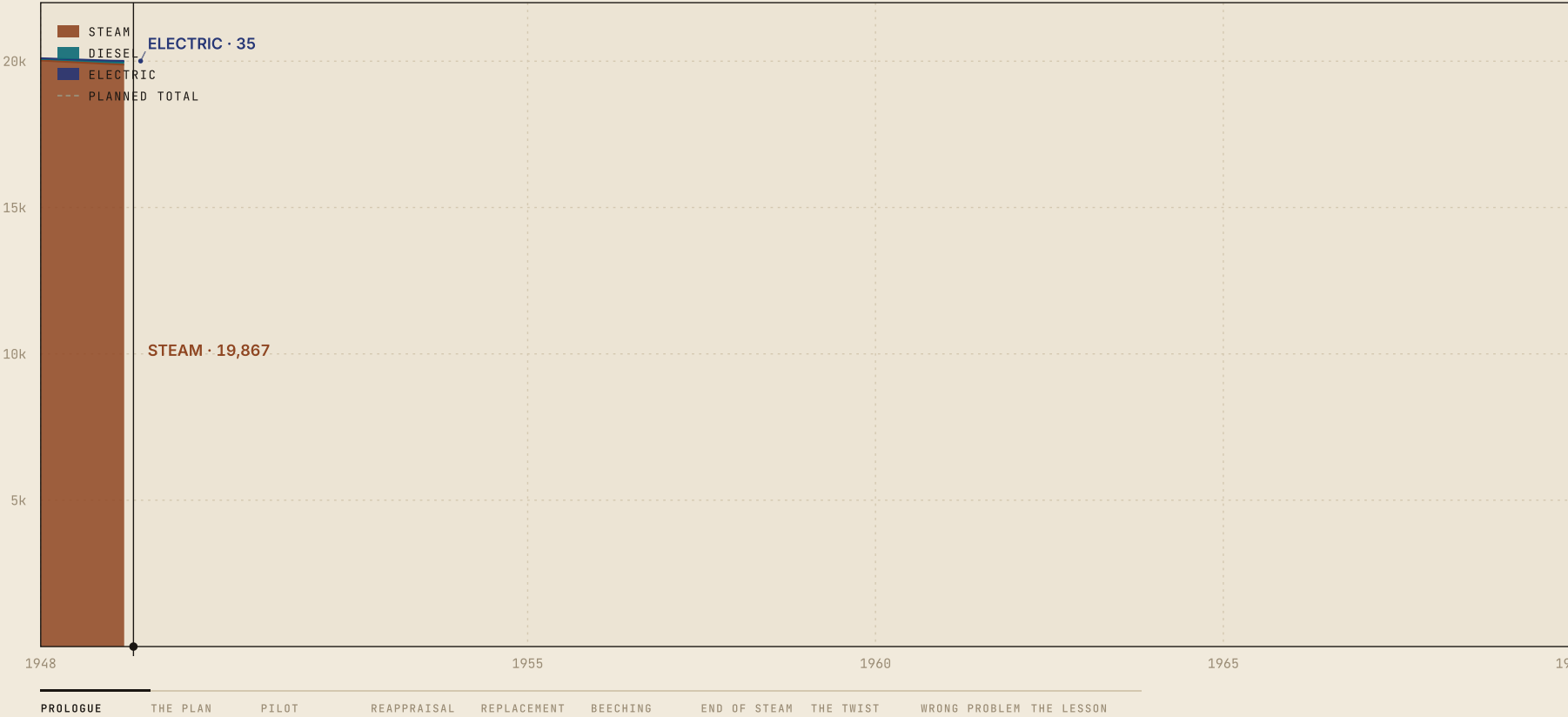
# The fleet that solved *the wrong problem.*

In 1955 British Railways committed £1.24 billion to replacing 18,000 steam locomotives with diesel and electric traction. Twelve years late and £400 million over budget, the job was done — and many of the new diesels were being scrapped before the steam they had replaced.

■ STEAM ■ DIESEL ■ ELECTRIC -- PLANNED

The fleet that solved *the wrong problem*

1949



PROLOGUE

THE PLAN

PILOT

REAPPRAISAL

REPLACEMENT

BEECHING

END OF STEAM

THE TWIST

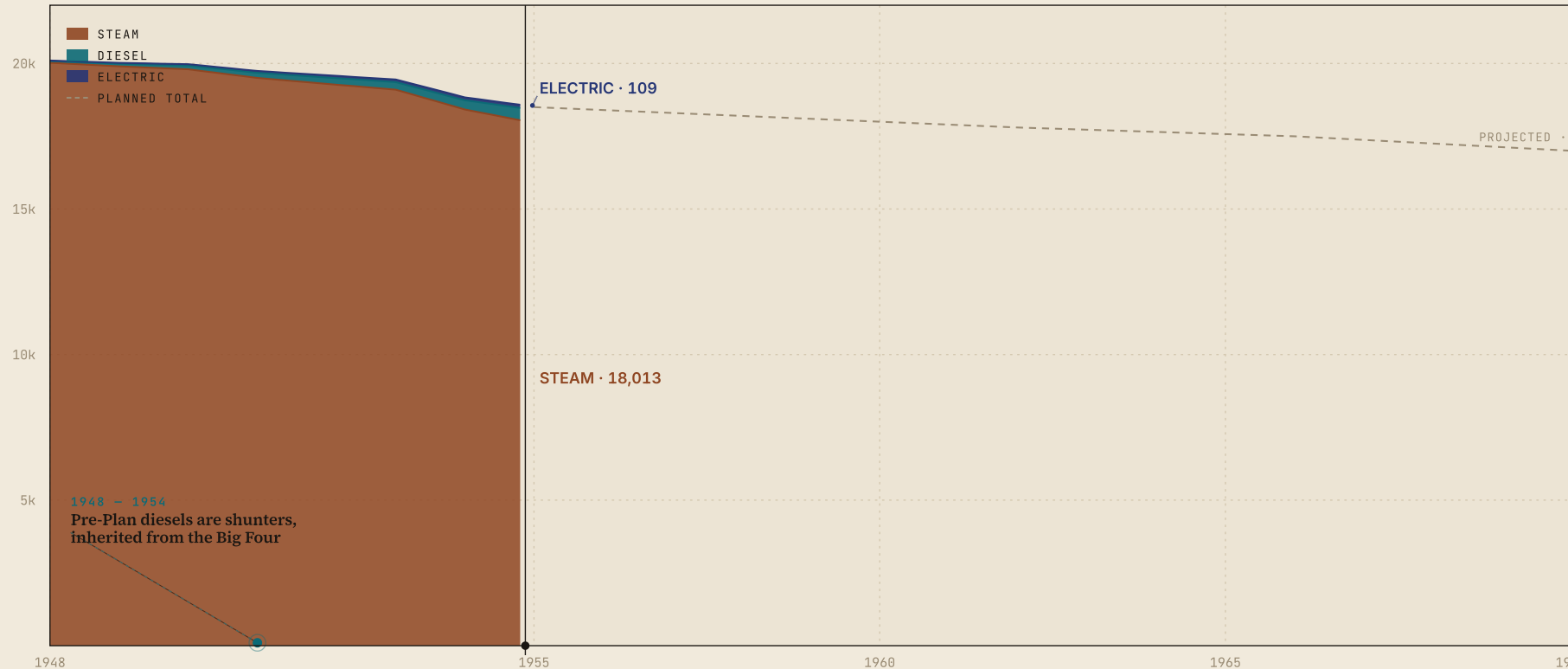
WRONG PROBLEM THE LESSON

PROLOGUE • 1948

British Railways inherits 20,000 steam locomotives.

# The fleet that solved *the wrong problem*

1954



PROLOGUE THE PLAN PILOT REAPPRAISAL REPLACEMENT BEECHING END OF STEAM THE TWIST WRONG PROBLEM THE LESSON

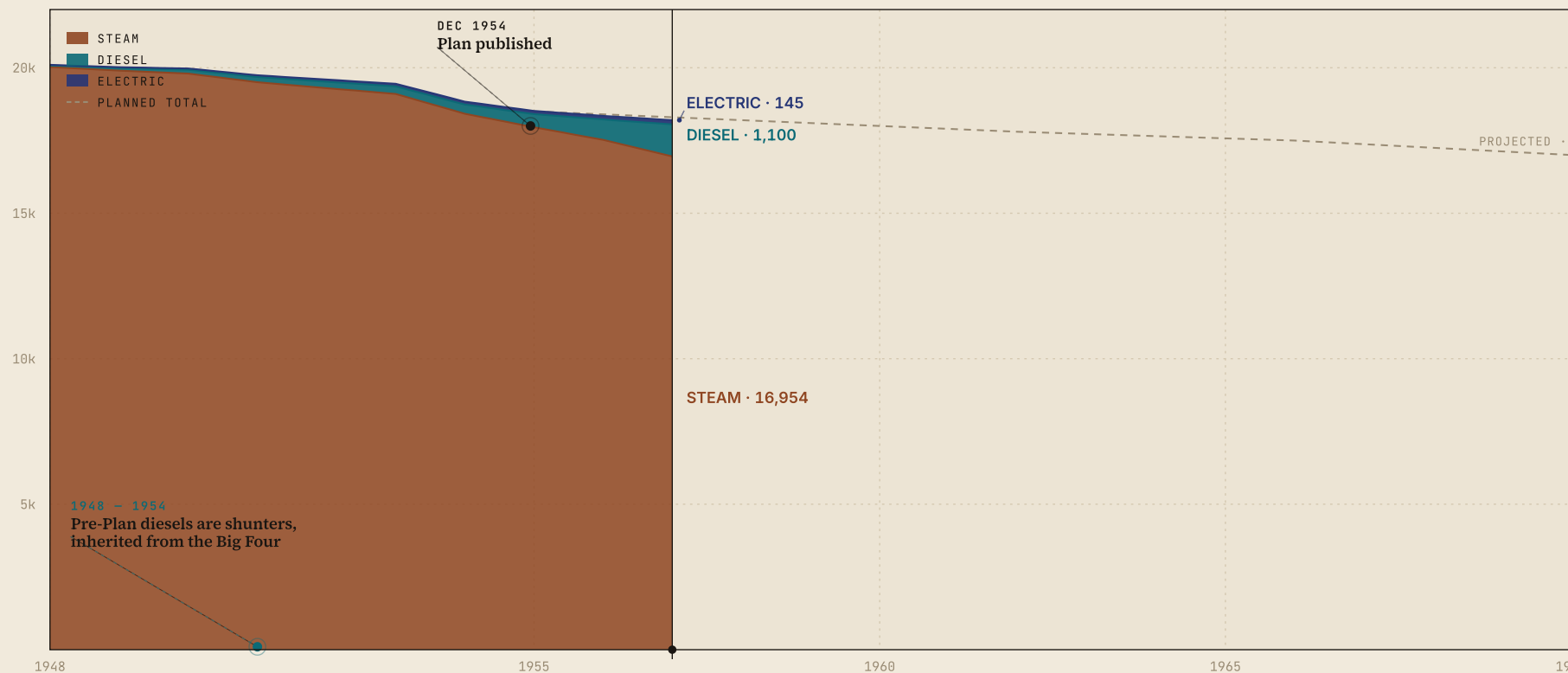
DECEMBER 1954

The Modernisation Plan: £1.24 billion over fifteen years.

The fleet that solved *the wrong problem*

YEAR

1957



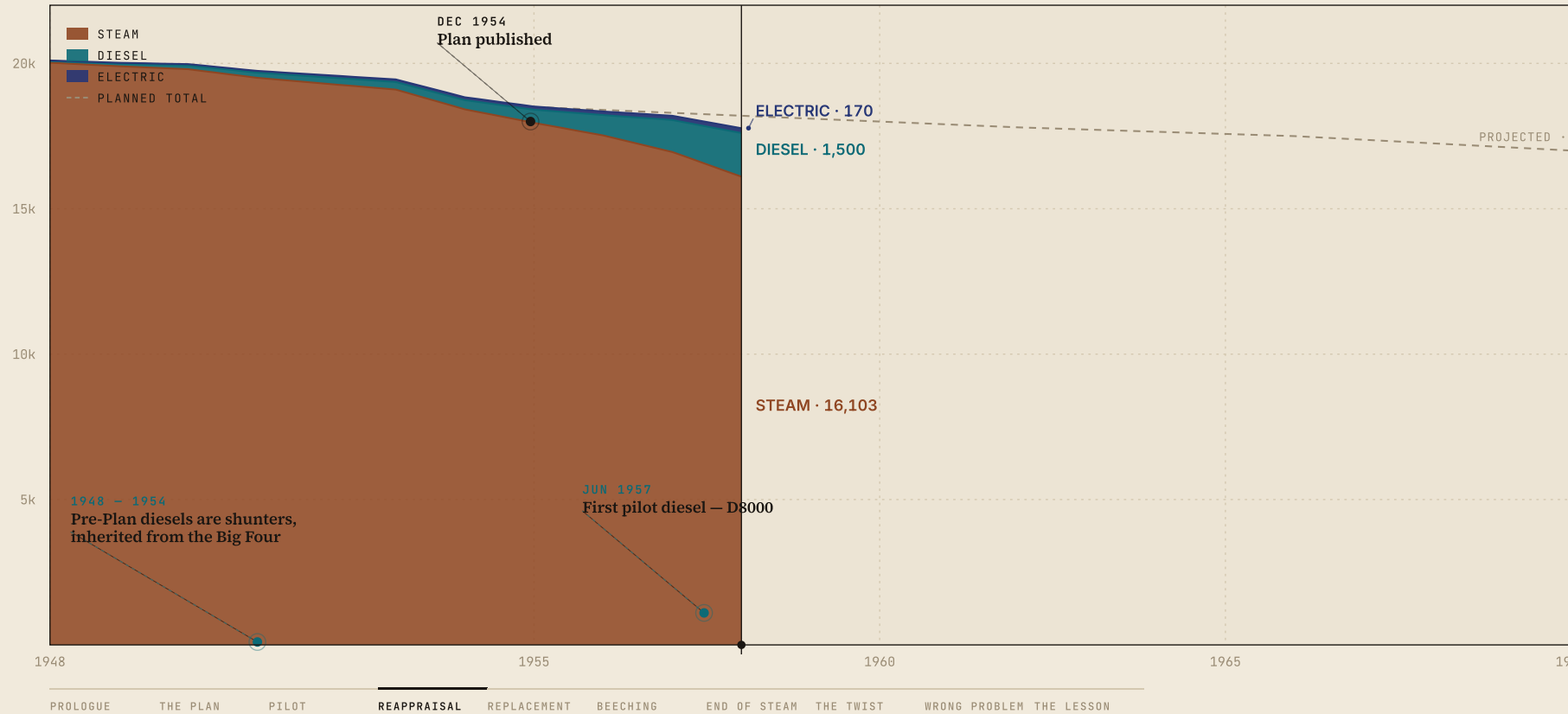
PROLOGUE THE PLAN PILOT REAPPRAISAL REPLACEMENT BEECHING END OF STEAM THE TWIST WRONG PROBLEM THE LESSON

## 1955 – 1957 • THE PILOT SCHEME

A sensible plan: test small batches, then standardise on the best.

# The fleet that solved *the wrong problem*

# 1958

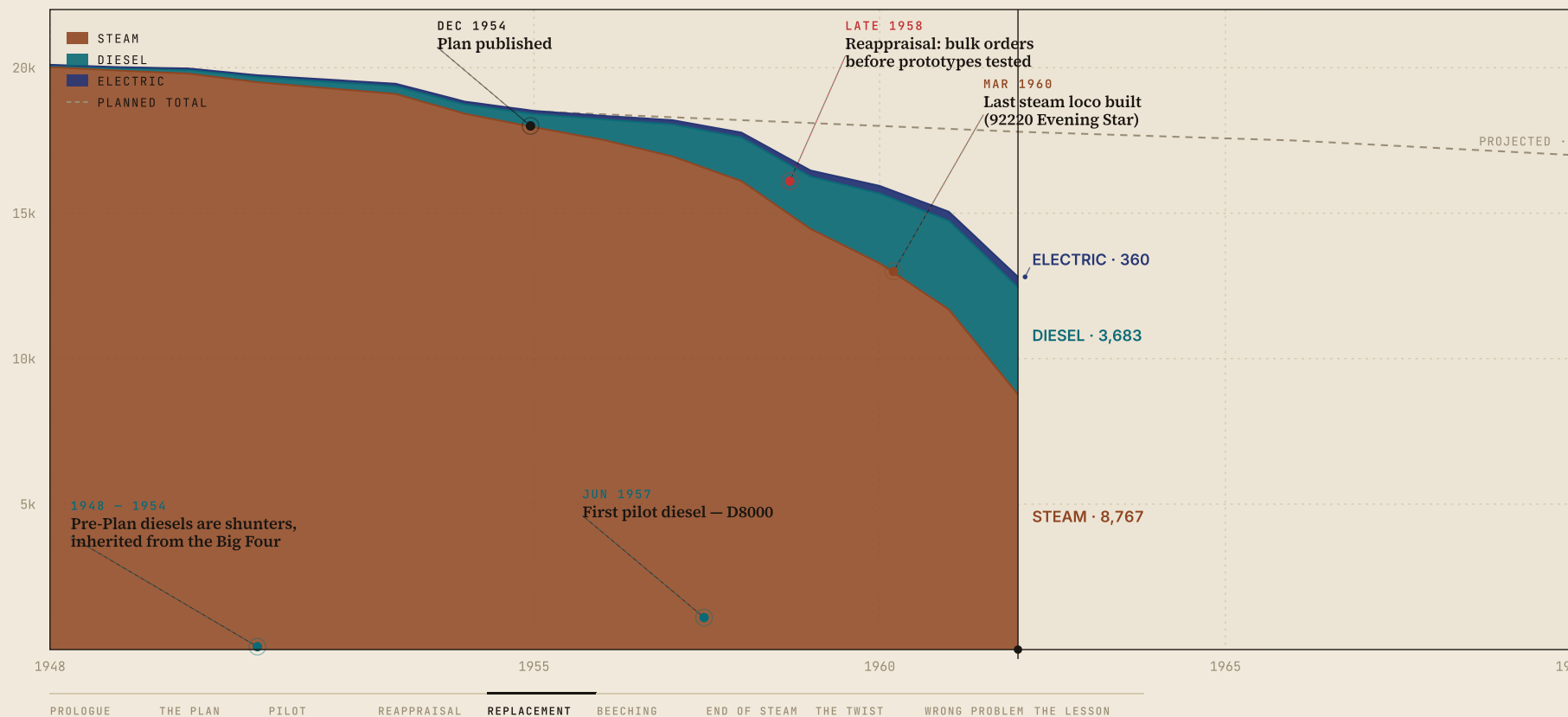


## LATE 1958 • THE REAPPRAISAL

BR can't wait. Orders are placed before prototypes are tested.

# The fleet that solved *the wrong problem*

1962

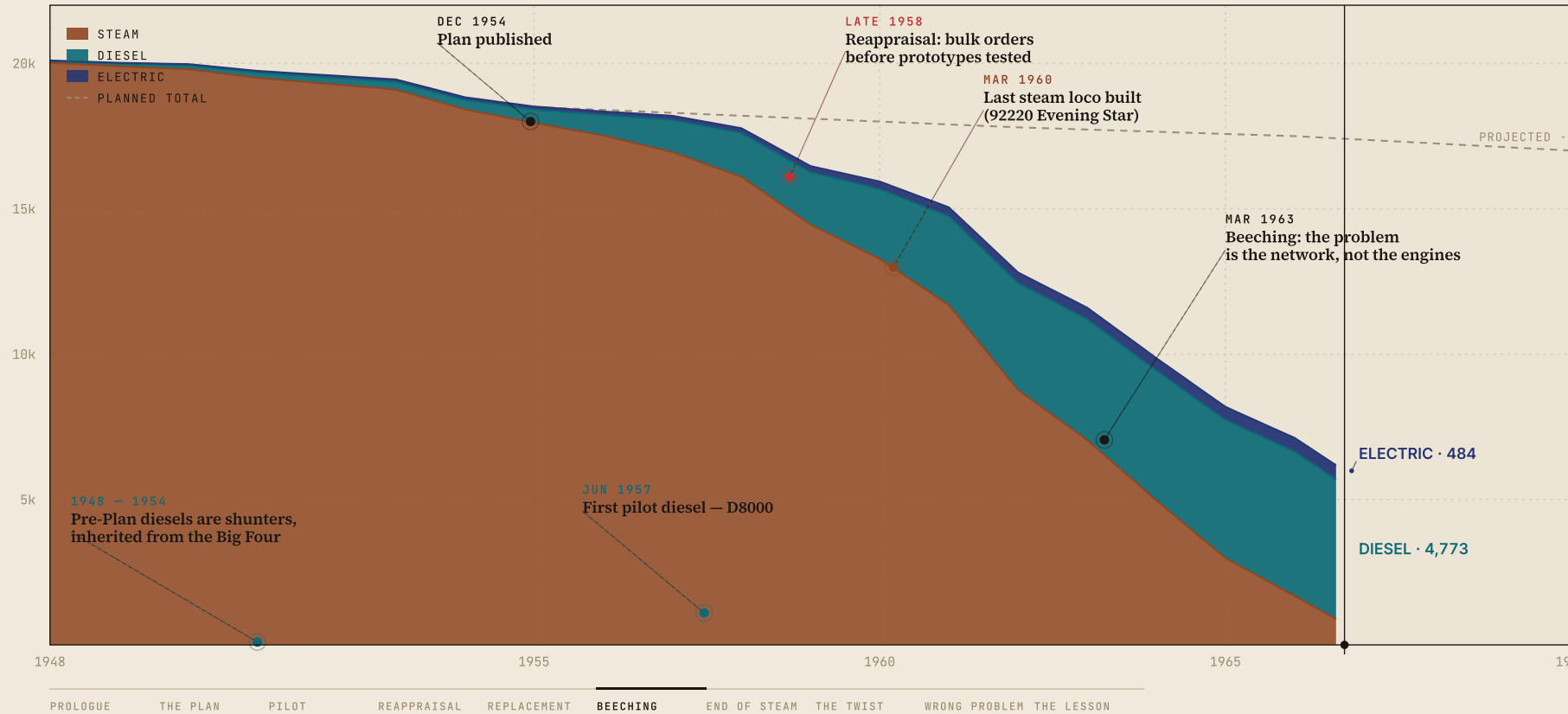


1959 – 1966 • THE REPLACEMENT

## Steam falls off a cliff. Diesels arrive in waves.

# The fleet that solved *the wrong problem*

YEAR  
1966

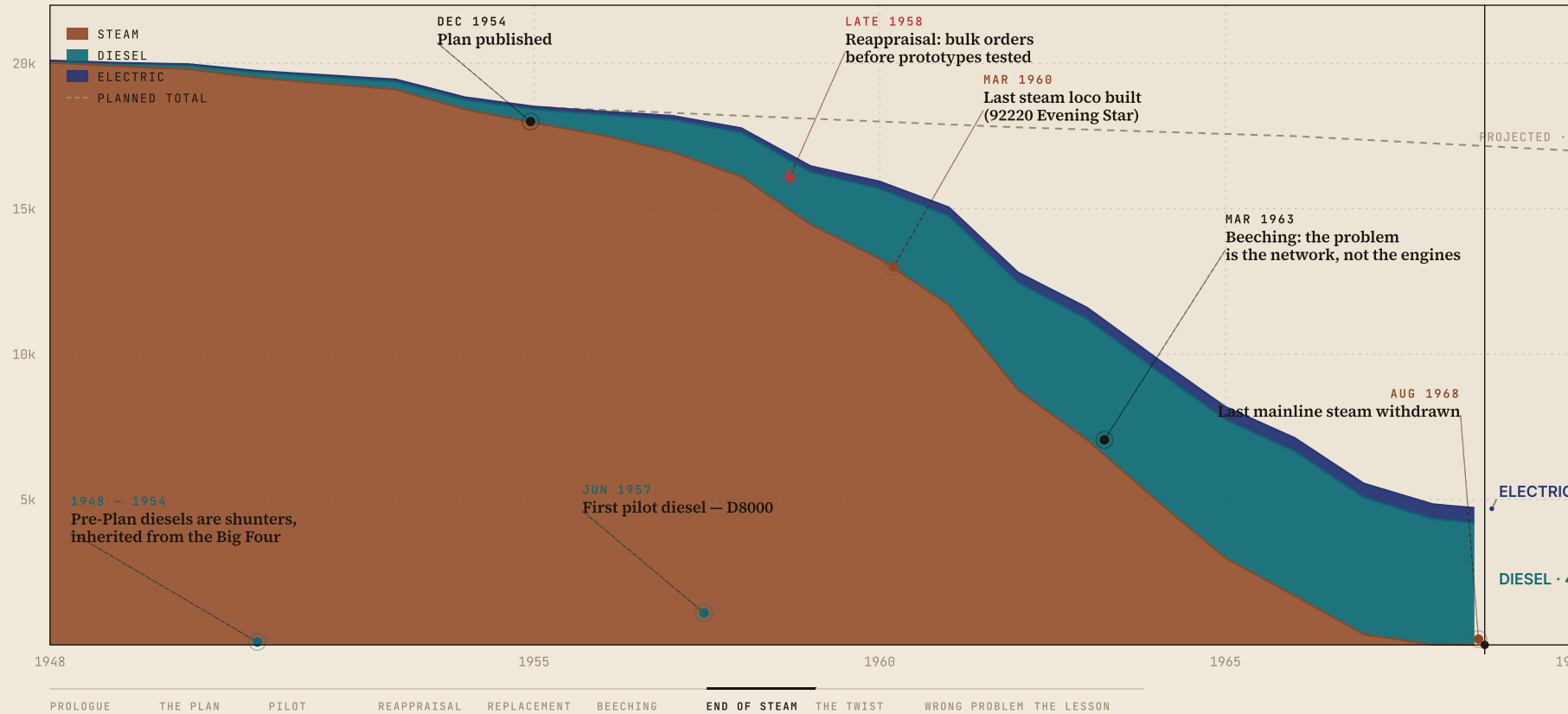


MARCH 1963 • BEECHING

Halfway through the rollout, a different report arrives.

# The fleet that solved *the wrong problem*

# 1968



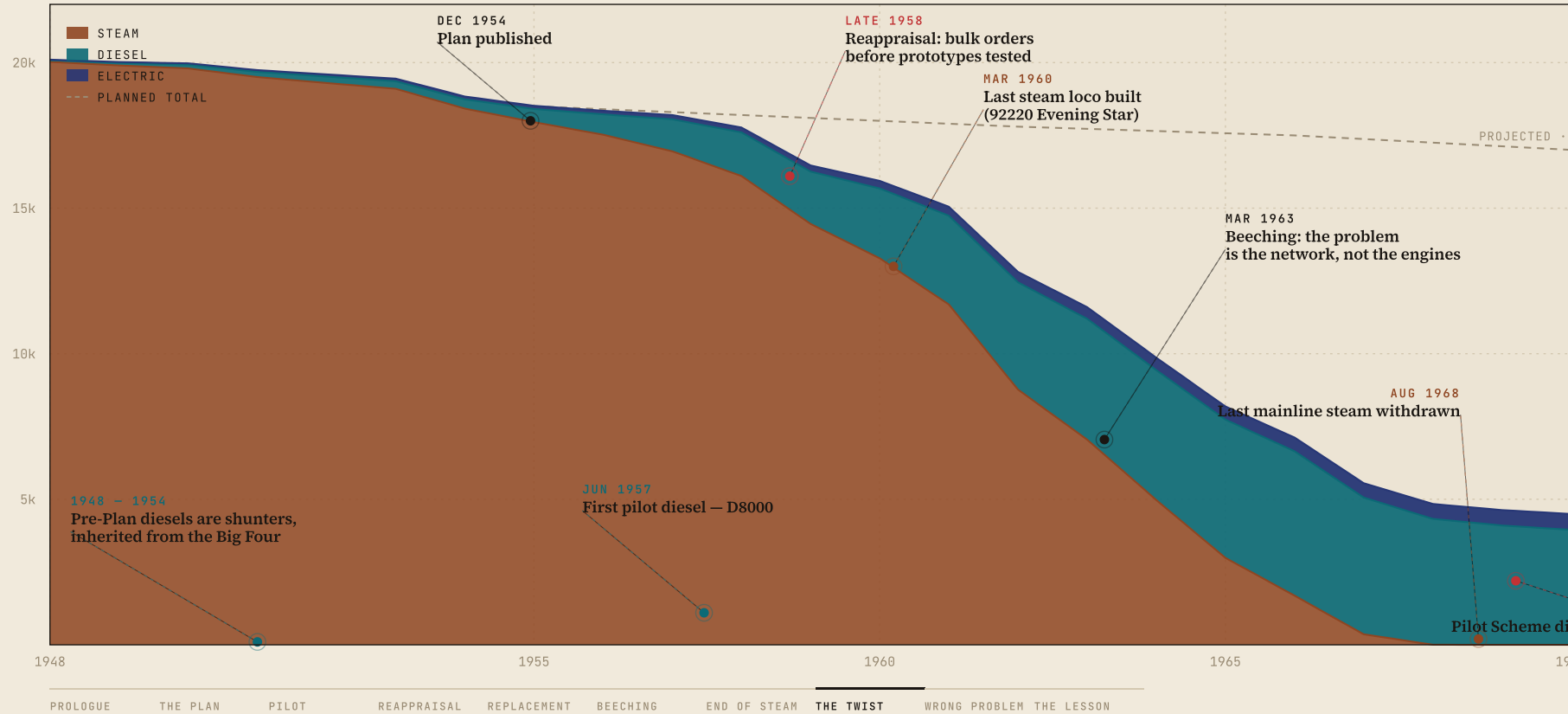
11 AUGUST 1968

The last mainline steam train runs. The Plan, on paper, is complete.



# The fleet that solved *the wrong problem*

1971

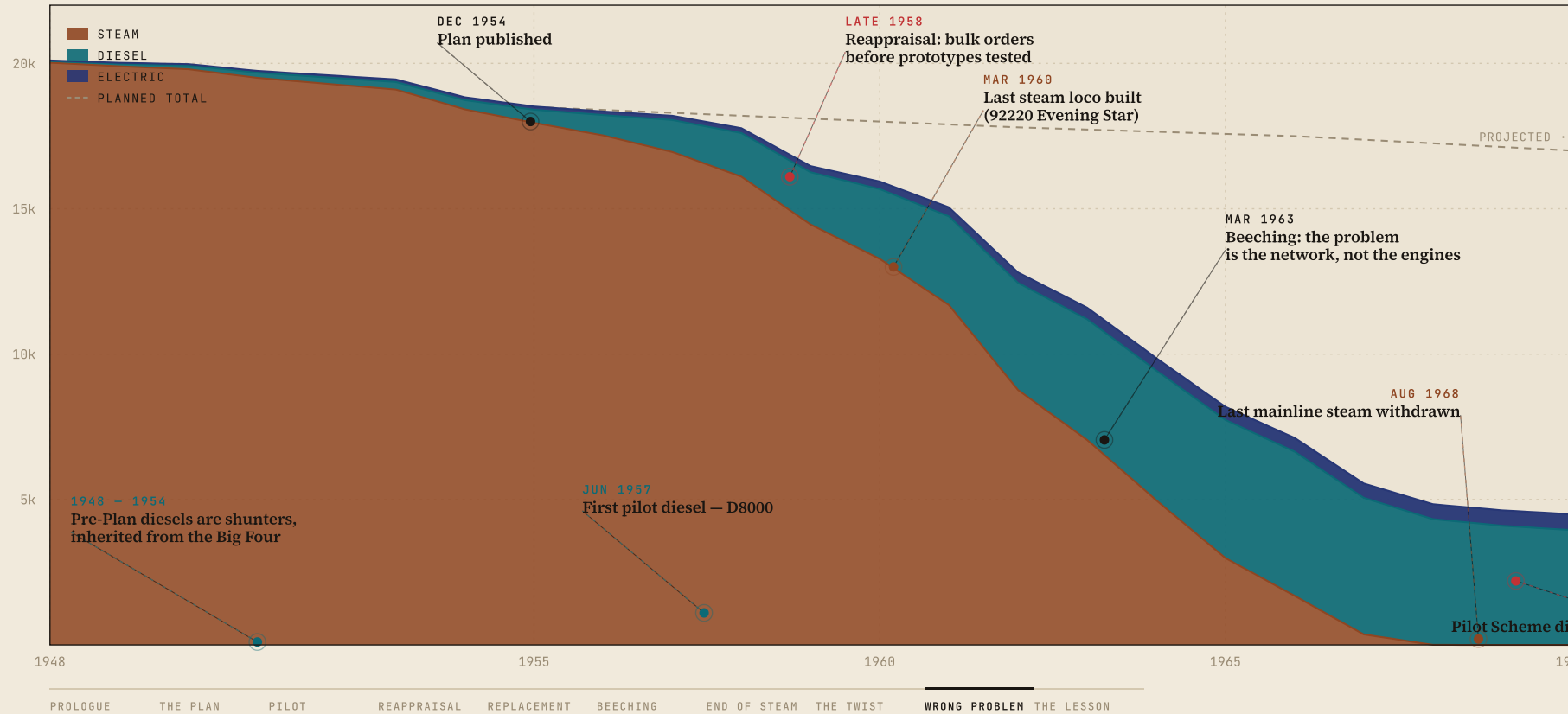


THE TWIST • 1967 – 1971

The new diesels start being scrapped — some after just five years.

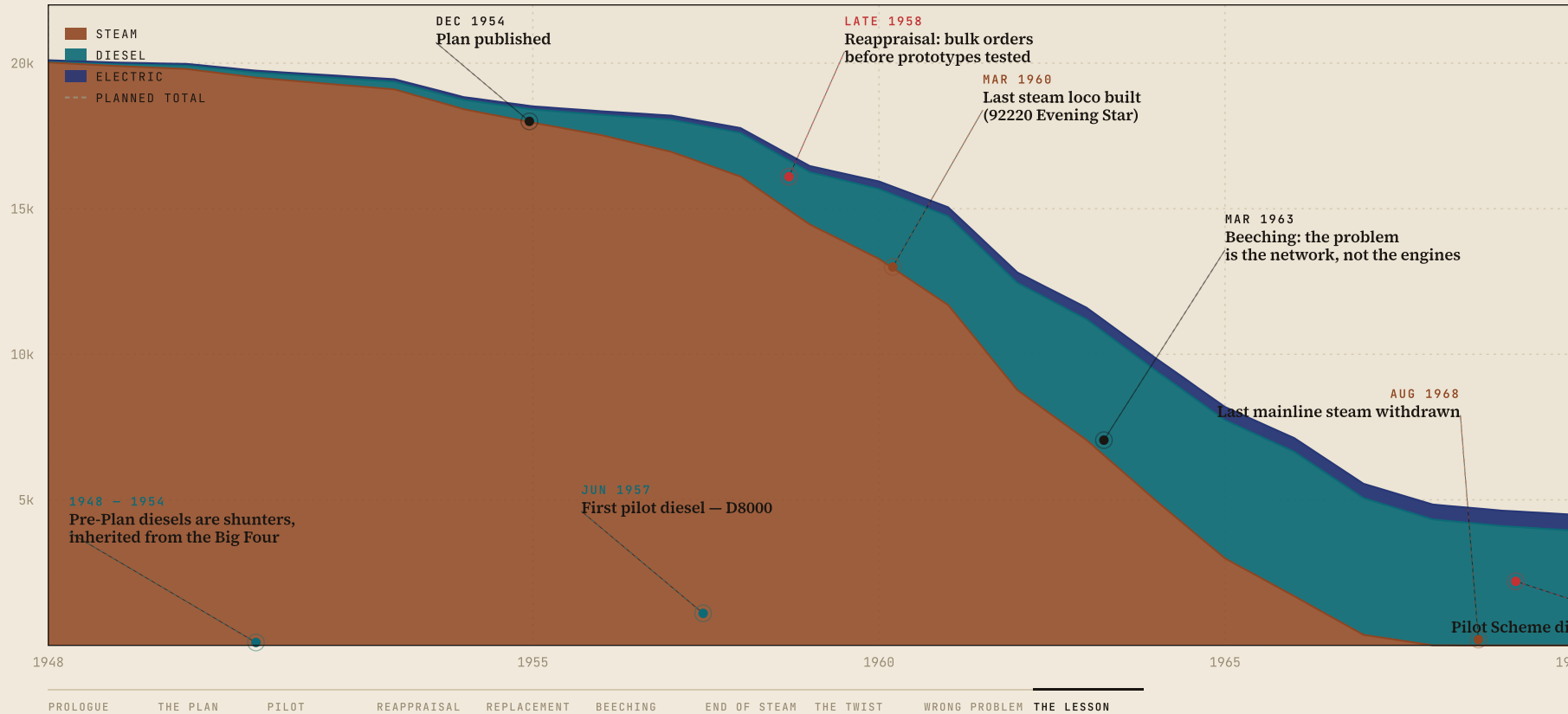
# The fleet that solved *the wrong problem*

1972



# The fleet that solved *the wrong problem*

1972



## THE LESSON

**Bolting new tech onto an old workflow looks like modernisation. It rarely is.**

The 1955 Plan asked how to replace each steam locomotive. The right question was what a 1965 railway should actually do — and most of the answer wasn't traction at all.

SOURCE • RCTS LOCOMOTIVE STOCK BOOKS • BR ANNUAL REPORTS